MUSKEGON COUNTY FOOD POLICY NETWORK

FOOD POLICY?

FOOD POLICY IS MOSTLY LOCAL POLICY

RULES SHAPE WHAT WE EAT, WHERE WE BUY IT, AND IF WE CAN AFFORD. THEY ARE MOSTLY MADE LOCALLY.

FEDERAL GOVERNMENT MAKES RULES & FUNDS PROGRAMS

Federal law creates big programs like SNAP, school lunch, and WIC. The Federal government it sets minimum standards, states and counties decide how those programs actually run in your community.

STATES IMPLEMENT PROGRAMS & FILL IN THE GAPS

States (through our governor, our State House of Reps and State Senate) pass food safety laws, set agriculture budgets, and decide how much flexibility counties get. But day-to-day implementation still lands locally.

LOCAL GOVERNMENT MAKES THE REAL CALLS

Zoning laws, business permits, health inspections, land use, public land for gardens, food truck rules, where grocery stores can be built,these decisions happen at city hall and the county building, not in Washington D.C.

CITY & LOCAL GOVERNMENT

WHO THEY ARE AND WHAT FOOD DECISIONS DO THEY ACTUALLY MAKE

WHO THEY ARE

- Mayor
- City Council / City Commission
- City Manager / Administrator
- Planning & Zoning Board
- City Health Department
- Parks & Recreation Dept

Elected officials set city budgets and pass local ordinances. Staff departments implement them.

ZONING & LAND USE

Cities decide where grocery stores, food trucks, corner stores, and community gardens can be located — or banned.

FARMERS MARKET PERMITS

The city issues (or denies) permits for outdoor markets. Rules on who can sell, what they can sell, and where.

PUBLIC LAND & GARDENS

Cities control whether vacant lots become community gardens or get sold for development. A single vote can change a food landscape.

BUSINESS LICENSING

Health inspections and operating permits for any business selling food — from restaurants to co-ops to corner stores.

COUNTY GOVERNMENT

THE LAYER BETWEEN THE CITY AND THE STATE, OFTEN OVERLOOKED, BUT CONTROLS A LOT

WHO THEY ARE

- Board of County Commissioners
- County Health Department
- County Extension Office (MSU)
- County Social Services / DHS
- County Planning Department
- County Clerk & Administration

Commissioners are elected. Departments are run by staff. In Michigan, the county board controls the county budget.

PUBLIC HEALTH REGULATION

The county health dept inspects food businesses, investigates outbreaks, and sets environmental health standards countywide.

LAND USE & AGRICULTURE

County planning shapes rural land use: which farmland gets protected, where distribution centers can be built, agricultural zoning.

SNAP & BENEFITS OUTREACH

County DHS offices process SNAP applications and connect residents to benefits — the frontline of federal food programs.

EXTENSION SERVICES

MSU Extension operates through the county, providing food safety training, nutrition education, and farm business support.

SNAP OR FOOD STAMPS
THREE LEVELS OF GOVERNMENT

THE FEDS WRITE THE LAW, BUT IT TAKES 3 LEVELS OF GOVERNMENT TO PUT FOOD ON THE TABLE

FEDERAL
U.S. Dept. of Agriculture (USDA)

- Sets eligibility rules on who qualifies
- Funds 100% of the food stamps cost
- Sets rules on what can and cannot be purchased (hot food, alcohol, vitamins — all excluded)
- Decides which retailers accept SNAP

STATE
Michigan Dept. of Health & Human Services

- Runs the application system (MI Bridges)
- Michigan: Double Up Food Bucks lets SNAP stretch further at farmers markets
- Manages EBT card issuance and replacements
- Trains county caseworkers

LOCAL
County DHS Office & Community Partners

- County DHS offices accept and process applications in person
- Local outreach workers help people apply (community orgs, food banks)
- Cities decide whether to accept SNAP at city-run markets
- **Food policy councils can advocate for SNAP-friendly policies locally**

MUSKEGON COUNTY FOOD POLICY NETWORK

WHAT IS BIAS?

WHAT IS BIAS IN DATA & REPORTS?

A PLAIN-LANGUAGE PRIMER FOR FOOD POLICY NETWORK MEMBERS

THE SIMPLE DEFINITION

Bias in a report means the results are tilted in a direction, not because of what is actually happenning in the world, but because of choices made in how the study was designed, who was included, or how results were presented.

NOT THE SAME AS LYING

Bias can be unintentional. Researchers, funders, and report writers often don't realize their methods are skewing results.

WHY DOES BIAS MATTER TO YOU?

REPORTS SHAPE POLICY

When a food access report shows that a neighborhood is "well served," that finding can stop funding or programs from reaching real need. If the report was biased, for example, only counting grocery stores but not their prices, the policy response will miss the mark.

DATA IS POWER

Network members are often subjects of these reports. Knowing how bias works helps you spot when your community's experience has been left out or misrepresented, and gives you language to push back.

BETTER QUESTIONS = BETTER OUTCOMES

You don't need to be a researcher to ask: Who funded this? Who was surveyed? What wasn't measured? Those three questions alone can reveal a lot about how much to trust a finding.

BIAS TYPES THAT MATTER FOR FOOD POLICY WORK

SELECTION BIAS

Who was included?

When the people studied don't represent the full community. Example: a food access survey only reaching people with internet access misses those with the greatest need.

FUNDING BIAS

Who paid for it?

Studies funded by industry or advocacy groups tend to find results that favor the funder. Always check: who commissioned this report and what did they want to find?

MEASUREMENT BIAS

How was it measured?

When the way data is collected systematically skews results. E.g., counting only licensed food businesses misses food clubs, cooperatives, and informal food sharing networks.

CONFIRMATION BIAS

Did they find what they expected?

Researchers (consciously or not) emphasize findings that match their hypothesis and downplay those that don't. Look for what a report doesn't mention as much as what it does.

REPORTING BIAS

What got left out?

Positive or dramatic results get published; neutral or negative ones don't. A network citing "studies show X" should ask: how many studies showed the opposite but were never published?

FRAMING BIAS

How was it described?

The same data can tell very different stories depending on word choice. "11.8% food insecurity" vs. "1 in 8 families can't reliably afford food" are identical facts with very different emotional weight.

WHAT IS YOUR JOB?

SORRY, YOU HAVE HOMEWORK

WE PULLED TOGETHER A BUNCH OF REPORTS AND DATA WE'D LIKE YOU TO REVIEW, WITH BIASES IN. MIND

WE ALL HAVE BIASES, INCLUDING YOU!

- What preconceived notions and/or perspectives do I bring into this analysis?
- Am I un/intentionally looking to confirm my own bias?
- Is correlation being confused with causation in the analysis?
- Does there appear to be data missing that would help form a more complete picture?
- What questions does this raise? What feels left unanswered?

REPORTS FUNDERS & AUTHORS, TOO

- Who designed the data collection and what was their motivation?
- When was the data collected? How have societal/community conditions changed since then?
- Is the data truly representative? Who was included vs. excluded from the data set?
- How is this data going to inform decision-making?

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MUSKEGON COUNTY FOOD POLICY NETWORK

MCFPN MEMBER ASSISTANT
MUSKEGON COUNTY FOOD POLICY NETWORK

2026 Training Series | Intro & Overview | Member Roster | ← Tierra Local

ASSISTANT IS ONLINE

YOUR GUIDE TO LOCAL FOOD POLICY

New here? Ask anything about food policy, the network's work, or how to get involved — get a plain, clear answer instantly.

QUICK LINKS

- **Network Intro & Overview** — What MCFPN is and how it works →
- **2026 Training Series Dates** — All 6 sessions — times & topics →
- **Member Roster & Contacts** — Connect with fellow members →

UPCOMING SESSIONS

SUNDAY, MAY 3
Session 2 — Understanding Local Food System Issues · 9 AM–5 PM
IN-PERSON

THURSDAY, JUNE 11
Session 3 — Moving Toward Action · 6–8 PM
VIRTUAL

THURSDAY, AUG 20
Session 4 — Campaign Finalization · 6–8 PM
IN-PERSON

TUESDAY, OCT 13
Session 5 — Campaign Rollout · 6–8 PM
IN-PERSON

THURSDAY, DEC 10
Session 6 — Public Presentation ·

MCFPN MEMBER ASSISTANT

Ask about food policy, local food systems, or the network's work

RY ASKING

- What do food policy councils do?
- Policies that help local farmers?
- What is my role as a member?
- Fighting hunger in Muskegon?
- Food council & local markets?
- What is a food club?
- What should I read first?

Welcome to the MCFPN Member Assistant!

I'm here to help you understand food policy and the network's work in Muskegon County — in plain, simple language.

New here? Click one of the questions above, or type your own below!

Ask anything about food policy or the MCFPN...

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NETWORK RESOURCE LIBRARY

Click any card to open

All resources | Network | Muskegon | Food Policy

Community Health Needs Assessment 2024
Health and food access data for Muskegon County.
★ WORTH NOTING
The food access section shows which zip codes have the least access to healthy food.
Muskegon — Muskegon County

Muskegon Food Club Feasibility Study 2024
Needs assessment and food club model for Muskegon County.
★ WORTH NOTING
Slide 27 has the full model and summary of what a food club would look like.
Muskegon — New Venture Advisors

Agriculture Cluster Impact Analysis 2026
Economic value of local farming and food production in Muskegon.
★ WORTH NOTING
The summary page has total impact numbers — great for conversations with officials and funders.
Muskegon — Muskegon

West Michigan Ag Cluster (Combined) —
Regional farming economic footprint across West Michigan.
★ WORTH NOTING
Compare Muskegon's numbers to the region shows where there is room to grow.
Muskegon — West Michigan

MSU Case Study: Lakeshore Flavor —
Equitable access to local food along Michigan's lakeshore.
★ WORTH NOTING
The equity findings show barriers keeping local food out of reach for lower-income families.
Muskegon — MSU

Feeding Michigan Families 2024
Statewide food insecurity data and program gaps.
★ WORTH NOTING
The program gaps section shows where policy can fill gaps existing programs miss.
Muskegon — State of Michigan

Feeding America West Michigan Annual Report 2023
Regional food bank report — 28M pounds distributed in 2023.
★ WORTH NOTING
Impact by County page: Muskegon had 37 active partners and an 11.8% food insecurity rate.
Muskegon — Feeding America

Food Policy Council Census Results 2023
National survey of how food policy councils are structured and what they accomplish.
★ WORTH NOTING
The accomplishments section shows the most common FPC wins and how long they take.
Food Policy — Johns Hopkins

Characteristics of Regional FPCs in the US —
What makes regional food policy councils effective.
★ WORTH NOTING
The governance models section identifies what the most successful FPCs do differently.
Food Policy — Research